

OBJECTIONS

- A section of the Hyde Act which stipulates that India will need to annually file a report on its nuclear energy programme. The report will have to be submitted to the US Government each year, for 40 years of the agreement.
- Another area of the Hyde Act which gives the US President the right to review the agreement if he/she should sense inconsistencies from India's side. If India conducts nuclear tests, the agreement would be terminated.
- Articles in the main agreement that deal with reprocessing of spent fuel and IAEA inspections. The US has the right to call for IAEA inspections in India whenever it deems fit.
- UPA Government's unwillingness to first explore non-conventional energy sources at home and in the subcontinent. Nuclear power generation is the most expensive energy option. The Government should look at coal, gas and hydro.

through. If the Congress decides to further the agreement by asking Atomic Energy Commission Chairperson Anil Kakodkar to negotiate India-specific safeguards at the IAEA in Vienna in mid-September, the Left will withdraw support. At least that seems to be the conviction of the Politburo. Bengali Marxists have been keen to project their pursuit of closeness with the Congress by ruling out the Government's collapse but most Politburo members are solidly behind Karat's hardline.

SURVIVAL TACTICS: Government versus the party, who will prevail?

that is on one front. On the flip side, the defence minister seems to have unconsciously added to the rift. A written statement from him in the Rajya Sabha on August 29 could be used by the Left against the Congress. By Antony's own admission, joint exercises between the armed forces of India and those of the US have increased since 2003. Minister of State in the PMO Prithviraj Chauhan also reiterated inside Parliament the Government's eagerness to review the Atomic Energy Act 1962. Chauhan said that by amending the Act, the private sector could participate in generation of nuclear energy.



SIPRA DAS

SONIA GANDHI AND MANMOHAN ARE CAUGHT IN A BIND OF THEIR OWN MAKING

policy initiatives since May 2004. But the nuclear agreement with the US seems to have tilted the balance of power within the UPA. Although UPA allies have officially backed the prime minister's tough stance, restlessness has crept into the RJD, DMK and NCP camps. Most UPA allies wish to stay in power till 2009. They cannot help but blame the prime minister if the Government is not allowed to complete its full term.

The UPA is the Congress' first coalition experiment at the Centre. The rising perception within the ruling alliance is that the Congress cannot handle coalitions well. But Sonia is in an unenviable position. If the Left does not endorse the nuclear agreement in the joint committee, the deal will fall

The much awaited debate on the subject in Parliament is slated for the first week of September. Sources said that the Congress would first try to sort out its differences within the joint committee. A debate in Parliament would mean involvement of more opposing parties such as the BJP and the UNPA. Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee has already hinted at an unholy truce between the Congress and the Left. At a public rally in Kolkata, Banerjee said, "The CPI(M) finds itself cornered and is trying to buy time to forge a compromise formula so that it can delay the elections and topple the UPA Government at a time when it suits them."

Antony has been assisting Mukherjee to diffuse the tension. But

The Left Front, which had stalled Antony's attempt to allow private participation in defence projects, is quite likely to take on the Congress on this and other issues like inflation. The Left had so far been blamed for a disorganised campaign against the nuclear agreement. In the last few days, members of the Left academia who had distanced themselves from the Left Front—particularly the CPI(M) after the Nandigram incident—have taken to the streets. With the latest agreement, the Left will only believe that its pressure tactics are working. The Congress, meanwhile, knows that time is running out and it will have to tread extremely carefully in the coming days, trapped as it is, between a rock and a very hard place. ■